



Harnessing Technology

Making effective use of technology will speed up communication, improve engagement with your customers, and enable you to work more efficiently.

Investing in technology

Even the smallest, one-person business faces a mind-boggling array of software, applications (apps), and other digital tools, all offering constantly changing features and benefits. Most will add purchasing and training costs to your business, so deciding how and when to invest in technology requires careful consideration.

Every business has specific technology needs, increasingly driven by the expectation of clients or customers, such as the ability to book services and pay for goods online. It is easy to overspend on

hardware—such as computers or printers—and software that is not strictly necessary or offers only short-term benefits, so it can be worth paying for specialized advice.

A technology expert will consider your business activities and digital options, then make a plan for your immediate requirements, while also allowing for future capacity to be easily integrated. You cannot future-proof technology, but you can build some adaptability into your tech systems by choosing hardware and software that can easily be expanded and updated over time.

DATA SECURITY

As your business grows, it will hold increasing volumes of data, such as customer cell phone numbers and email addresses and lists of suppliers or investors. It is essential to keep this data safe to protect your business and to ensure compliance with relevant local data regulations (see p.212). Businesses are increasingly vulnerable to hackers, malware, and other forms of cyber attack, so it is vital to ensure the security of your systems. Even the smallest business should take at least some simple steps to protect valuable data (see pp.120–121).

Working smarter

As part of an integrated technology plan, the right computer systems, data and management software, and apps can help you and your business work more efficiently and improve your products and services.

Whatever tools you decide to use, you should make sure they are compatible with each other, both in terms of technology and in how they work together to develop the business. Here are some examples of how utilizing technology could help your business.

Portable hardware

Portable devices such as laptops and hard drives enable colleagues to work remotely. Ensure colleagues can access files from devices out of the office.

Free software

Commercial software can be costly. Consider starting with free-to-use software and apps, but check that they are compatible and secure.

Cloud services

Online cloud servers are a way of using someone else's computers to store data and run programs. Reduce your costs by moving business functions to the cloud.